

Tenses

Unit 12 of 12 · Grammar Study Sheet

Master the 7 most common English tenses, one tense per lesson. Each lesson explains the rules, signal words, and when to use it — all referenced to IELTS exam-style questions.

What you will be able to do

- ✓ Use Present Simple for habits and facts
- ✓ Use Present Continuous for actions happening now and current trends
- ✓ Use Present Perfect for experiences and unfinished time
- ✓ Use Past Simple for completed past actions
- ✓ Use Past Continuous for ongoing past actions and background
- ✓ Use Future Simple (will) for predictions and spontaneous decisions
- ✓ Use Be going to for plans and predictions based on evidence
- ✓ Recognise tense signal words / time markers
- ✓ Identify the correct tense in IELTS-style exam questions

Topics: *present simple*

Form — Present Simple

Use for habits, routines, general truths, and permanent situations. Subject decides whether the verb takes -s (he/she/it) or not.

+	I/you/we/they + base verb; he/she/it + verb-s
–	I/you/we/they + don't + base; he/she/it + doesn't + base
?	Do I/you/we/they + base? Does he/she/it + base?

Examples:

- She works in an office every day.
- I don't drink coffee.
- Does he speak English?
- Water boils at 100°C. (general truth)
- My flight leaves at 6 a.m. tomorrow. (schedule)

When to use Present Simple

Pick this tense when the situation is habitual, permanent, or always-true.

Examples:

- HABITS — I go to the gym on Mondays.
- FACTS — The Earth revolves around the Sun.
- PERMANENT STATES — She lives in Paris.
- SCHEDULES — The train arrives at 10:15.
- Signal words: every day, usually, often, sometimes, always, never, on Mondays.

Topics: *present continuous*

Form — Present Continuous

be (am/is/are) + verb-ing. Spelling: drop final -e (write → writing), double consonant after 1 vowel (run → running), -ie → -y + -ing (lie → lying).

+	I am, he/she/it is, you/we/they are + verb-ing
–	subject + am/is/are NOT + verb-ing
?	Am/Is/Are + subject + verb-ing?

Examples:

- I am studying for my IELTS exam.
- It is raining right now.
- They aren't working today.

- Are you listening to me?
- My sister is learning Japanese this year. (temporary)

When to use Present Continuous

Action happening NOW, temporary situations, fixed future plans, and changing trends. Don't use with stative verbs (know, love, believe, want).

Examples:

- NOW — Look! It is raining outside.
- TEMPORARY — I am living with my parents this month.
- FUTURE ARRANGEMENT — We are meeting at 7 p.m. tomorrow.
- TREND — More people are working from home these days.
- Signal words: now, right now, at the moment, today, this week, these days, Look!, Listen!

Lesson 12c · Present Perfect

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Topics: *present perfect*

Form — Present Perfect

have/has + past participle. Regular verbs: + -ed (work → worked). Irregular verbs: see page 182 list (go → gone, see → seen, write → written).

+	I/you/we/they have + past participle; he/she/it has + past participle
–	subject + haven't/hasn't + past participle
?	Have/Has + subject + past participle?

Examples:

- I have visited Japan three times.
- She has lived here since 2015.
- They haven't finished the project yet.
- Have you ever tried Korean food?
- He has just submitted his application.

When to use Present Perfect

Past action with present connection: experiences, unfinished time periods, recent actions with results that matter now.

Examples:

- EXPERIENCE — I have been to Italy. (any time in life)
- UNFINISHED TIME — She has lived here for five years. (still lives here)
- RECENT — They have just arrived. (= a moment ago + still relevant)
- CHANGE OVER TIME — Technology has changed dramatically since 2000.
- Signal words: ever, never, just, already, yet, since + point in time, for + duration, recently, this year, so far.

Topics: *past simple*

Form — Past Simple

Regular verbs: + -ed. Irregular verbs: each has its own form (see page 182). Negatives and questions use "did" + base form — for ALL subjects.

+	subject + verb-ed (worked) / irregular past form (went)
-	subject + didn't + BASE verb (not the past form)
?	Did + subject + BASE verb?

Examples:

- I worked in Paris in 2019.
- She didn't finish her homework. (NOT didn't finished)
- Did you watch the news?
- Shakespeare wrote over 30 plays. (irregular)
- They went to the cinema yesterday.

When to use Past Simple

Completed action at a definite past time. The most-used past tense.

Examples:

- DEFINITE PAST — I lived in London in 2018.
- SEQUENCE — She got up, made coffee, and left for work.
- PAST HABIT — When I was a child, I read a lot.
- PAST STATE — He was a teacher for 30 years.
- Signal words: yesterday, last week/month/year, in 2010, two days ago, when I was a child, this morning.

Topics: *past continuous*

Form — Past Continuous

was/were + verb-ing. I/he/she/it → was. You/we/they → were.

+	I/he/she/it was + verb-ing; you/we/they were + verb-ing
–	subject + wasn't/weren't + verb-ing
?	Was/Were + subject + verb-ing?

Examples:

- I was watching TV at 8 p.m. yesterday.
- They were having a meeting when the fire alarm went off.
- She wasn't paying attention during the lecture.
- Were you sleeping when I called?
- It was raining heavily when we left.

When to use Past Continuous

Action in progress at a specific past moment. Often paired with past simple (the interrupted-action pattern).

Examples:

- AT A PAST MOMENT — At 7 p.m., I was having dinner.
- BACKGROUND — When I arrived, it was raining. (rain = background)
- INTERRUPTION — I was reading WHEN the phone rang.
- PARALLEL — While she was cooking, he was watching TV.
- Signal words: while, when (with interruption), at + time + yesterday/last week, all morning, during the meeting, this time last year.

Topics: future simple (will)

Form — Future Simple with "will"

will + BASE verb. Same for ALL subjects. Negative = will not = won't.

+	subject + will + base verb
–	subject + won't + base verb (= will not)
?	Will + subject + base verb?

Examples:

- I will help you with your homework.
- It won't rain tomorrow.
- Will you marry me?
- A: The phone is ringing. B: I'll answer it. (spontaneous)
- I think she'll pass the exam. (prediction)

When to use "will"

Predictions, spontaneous decisions at the moment of speaking, promises, offers, and future facts.

Examples:

- PREDICTION — I think it will rain tomorrow.
- SPONTANEOUS DECISION — I'm thirsty — I'll get a drink.
- PROMISE — I'll always love you.
- OFFER — I'll help you with the bags.
- CONDITIONAL — If you study hard, you WILL pass.
- Signal words: tomorrow, next week, soon, probably, I think, I expect, in the future.

Topics: be going to

Form — Be going to

am/is/are + going to + BASE verb. Use the present form of be.

+	I am, he/she/it is, you/we/they are + going to + base verb
–	subject + am not/Isn't/aren't + going to + base verb
?	Am/Is/Are + subject + going to + base verb?

Examples:

- I am going to start a new diet next week.
- She isn't going to apply for that job.
- Are you going to study tonight?
- Look at those clouds — it's going to rain. (evidence-based)

- We're going to get married in June. (planned)

When to use Be going to

Planned future (decision made BEFORE speaking) or prediction based on present evidence.

Examples:

- PLANNED ACTION — I'm going to study French next year. (already decided)
- EVIDENCE-BASED PREDICTION — Watch out! That glass is going to fall.
- INTENTION — She's going to be a doctor.
- IMMINENT — Hurry up — the train is going to leave!
- will vs be going to: "will" = decided NOW; "be going to" = decided BEFORE / based on evidence.
- Signal words: tomorrow, next week, on Friday, this weekend, tonight, Look! (with visible evidence)